

of the 2018 numbers... [in FY24], we should be able to surpass it. What we've been doing in Ashok Leyland is to ensure—knowing that the industry goes through a cycle—that the growth momentum and profitability of the company do not suffer. That's why we started diversifying into different segments like LCV, international operations growth, our parts business, defence business and power solutions business. All of these were [done] to ensure that irrespective of the business cycle, the business should not suffer.

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You should be prepared for when the cycle turns again...

We should prepare and, of course, the cost structure should also be corrected. One thing you always end up doing in every downturn is suddenly starting cost-cutting everywhere. In good times, there is

ties, we could still launch a new platform in the M&HCV range [the AVTR range of modular products in April 2020]. And we also launched the Bada Dost (pickup) in the LCV range in September 2020. As a result, our products are delivering very well, and we've been able to increase our network and infrastructure across the country. Traditionally, we've had weaknesses in the northern and eastern markets, which we've been able to correct now. And at the core of all of this is the people itself. I would give the credit for the growth over this last one year as well to how the team themselves have said 'we need to put the company back in shape'. So, they've risen to that.

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So, what is your core product strategy? There are the vehicles running on new fuels that you are planning. But those are very

drogen, CNG or LNG, and also which fuel type would be the most optimal in which segment. So, we've kept the strategy to ensure that whatever the requirements of the customer and depending on the cost of the fuel as well, Ashok Leyland should have end-to-end alternative fuel product options.

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You're not very big in the LCV market at this point, but you are growing fast. It has also not been a traditional segment for Ashok Leyland. Do you expect LCVs to contribute more to your sales?

In LCVs, [after buying out Nissan from a partnership in 2016], in a matter of one year, we were able to turn around the performance of the company, and they started becoming profitable, making good money. So, we decided we needed a higher platform as well. And that's where we got into the development of the Bada Dost product. So, today we have products from 2 tonne up-

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this tendency to start being a little more extravagant. But since September 2021, we have ensured that we maintain a low-cost structure.

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Now, there is a clear uptick in sales for Ashok Leyland as well as for the industry. Specifically for Ashok Leyland, what are the key factors contributing to this current growth?

First and foremost, we are a product company. And our products are performing exceptionally well across the country and even in international markets. During Covid-19, despite all the difficul-

small, and some of them have not even started. From a volume perspective, what is your overall product strategy?

In this industry, a new platform or a new introduction will not happen as regularly as you see in the car industry. So, having launched these new products nearly three years ago, in the current environment, we do not see many changes happening. But beyond that, we have prepared ourselves very well. We've got Switch Mobility for electric vehicles, buses and light vehicles. We don't know which of the alternate fuel strategies would work for the future, whether it's hy-

wards to 7.5 tonne. We do have certain gaps, which we need to fill in for the future as well. Traditionally, on a total volume basis, LCVs would normally comprise 60-65 per cent of the CV market, and the balance will be M&HCVs. So, it's a large market and one that we cannot stay away from, especially when you look at last-mile delivery. We are working on not only diesel and CNG options of our existing products, but Switch Mobility is also working on LCVs from an electric perspective. We feel quite confident that going forward, these lighter products will form a larger volume for the company. **BT**

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